livelihoods of 70 per cent of the labour forces employed in agriculture. Now, Fiji had been added to the prime minister's list of priorities. Within minutes, Tiwari was back in Gandhi's office.

The coup had taken place at about ten a.m. Fijian time (six hours ahead of Indian standard time), when ten soldiers entered the Fiji parliament and forcibly took over the barely one-month-old, multiracial government headed by Timoci Bavadra who had eight ethnic Indians in his cabinet.

Rajiv's mother, the late former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, had been at the forefront in the fight for Fiji's independence from the British in the 1970s. Tiwari reminded Rajiv that in 1970, even before the birth of indepen-A nation of three hundred and thirty islands, Fiji was ruled by the British from 1874 to October 1970. According to R&AW reports, the erstwhile colony located two thousand miles east of Australia housed a US Air Force station in Viti Levu Island that primarily functioned as a refuelling base for aircraft between the US west coast and Australia-New Zealand. At the time of Fiji's independence in 1970, it had become a major transit hub, hosting more than forty transnational flights every day.

A report by the US's Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) provides a brief background on Fiji:

When the Islands were first discovered by the British in 1643, they were populated by tribal peoples of essentially Melanesian descent, who now constitute the Fijian racial group. European colonisation was never appreciated. But after the British took control, large numbers of Indian labourers were imported from South Asia to work in the Island's sugar fields. Their descendants, most of whom are Hindus, presently outnumber